Saviours AI

ICSE CLASS 10 · 2027 SYLLABUS

SIDE KICK

English Language

Essays, letters, notices, e-mails, unseen passages and grammar, written fresh for the 2027 syllabus.



EVERY TOPPER HAS A SIDEKICK

saviours.pro

Hey. I'm your Sidekick.

I live inside this book. Wherever things get tricky, I pop up with a tip, a trap to dodge, or a question the board loves to ask. Read the chapter, then try my HOT questions. Deal?



Aligned to the official ICSE 2027 syllabus. If it's in the syllabus, it's in here.

SIDEKICK TIP
Shortcuts, mnemonics and exam hacks.

FUN FACT
Things that make the concept stick.

REAL LIFE
Where this shows up outside the exam hall.

KEY POINT
Definitions and laws you must write exactly.

HOT QUESTION
Higher-order thinking. Try before you peek.

✦ NEW
Added in this edition to match the 2027 syllabus.

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01

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Composition: Essay Writing

Question 1 carries the biggest single block of marks in Paper 1. You pick one topic out of several and write 300 to 350 words. This chapter shows you how to choose, plan, build and finish an essay that an examiner enjoys reading.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Topic types
- The 5-minute plan
- Paragraphs and connectors
- Openings and endings
- Five model essays
- Picture-based topics
- Mistakes that cost marks

What the Examiner Is Really Marking

The syllabus asks you to organise, describe, narrate, explain, persuade or argue, and to present ideas **coherently, accurately and precisely**. In plain words, the examiner looks at two things: **what you say** (content and organisation) and **how you say it** (grammar, spelling, punctuation, vocabulary, style).

MARKING AREA	WHAT EARNS MARKS	WHAT LOSES MARKS
Content	Ideas that match the topic, with examples from life	Wandering off the topic; learnt-by-heart essays that only half fit
Organisation	Clear opening, linked paragraphs, a real ending	One giant block of text; no ending
Language	Varied, correct sentences; fitting vocabulary	Repeated words, run-on sentences, careless spelling
Length	300 to 350 words	Below 250 or beyond 400



KEY POINT

Word limit: aim for **320 words**. Count a sample line of your handwriting once (say, 11 words a line) and then you can estimate length without counting every word in the exam.

Types of Composition

TYPE	YOUR JOB	TYPICAL QUESTION	TENSE AND TONE
Descriptive	Paint a scene, person or place so the reader can see it	Describe a railway station at midnight	Present or past; sensory, vivid
Narrative	Tell a story with a beginning, a turning point and an end	Write a story that ends with “and the door closed behind her.”	Past tense; fast-moving
Reflective	Think aloud about an idea, memory or experience	The most valuable lesson my grandfather taught me	Personal; thoughtful
Argumentative	Take one side and prove it	Mobile phones should be banned in schools	Formal; firm; reasons plus proof
Discursive	Weigh both sides, then give a balanced view	Is homework helpful or harmful?	Formal; balanced
Picture-based	Use the picture as a trigger for any of the above	Write on the scene shown in the picture	Depends on the angle you choose

SIDEKICK TIP

The words in the topic tell you the type. **Describe** means descriptive, **story** or **ending with** means narrative, **experience, feelings, lesson** mean reflective, and **should, ought, do you agree** mean argumentative or discursive.

Choosing Your Topic in Two Minutes

1. Read all topics
Spend a full minute. Do not grab the first one that looks familiar.

2. Test each one
Ask: can I get four different points or four scenes out of it? If you can only get two, drop it.

3. Prefer experience
The syllabus says topics let you draw on first-hand experience. A real memory is easier to write than an imagined statistic.

4. Commit
Once chosen, do not switch. Switching after ten minutes costs more than a weaker topic would.

The Five-Minute Plan

Strong writers do not start with sentence one. They start with a map. Jot this on the rough-work page:

```
TOPIC: ..............................
TYPE : descriptive / narrative / reflective / argumentative / discursive
PARA 1 (opening)   : hook + what the essay is about
PARA 2 (point 1)    : idea + example
PARA 3 (point 2)    : idea + example
PARA 4 (point 3)    : idea + example / twist
PARA 5 (ending)     : closing thought, not a repeat
```

Five paragraphs of 60 to 70 words each give you about 320 words, and the structure looks tidy to the examiner.

Building Paragraphs

A good paragraph has one job. Its first sentence announces the idea, the middle sentences prove or show it, and the last sentence ties it back to the topic.

- **One idea per paragraph.** If you change the idea, begin a new paragraph.
- **Show, do not just tell.** “The hall was crowded” is weak. “Students stood on benches and a few clung to the window bars” is strong.
- **Vary sentence length.** A short sentence after two long ones lands like a drumbeat.
- **Use specific nouns.** Write *marigold*, not *flower*; *stumbled*, not *walked badly*.

Connectors That Hold the Essay Together

JOB	WORDS YOU CAN USE
Add a point	moreover, in addition, besides, what is more, similarly
Contrast	however, on the other hand, yet, nevertheless, whereas, in contrast
Give a reason or result	because, since, as a result, consequently, therefore, hence
Give an example	for instance, for example, such as, to illustrate
Show time or order	at first, soon after, meanwhile, by dusk, eventually, finally
Conclude	in conclusion, on the whole, all things considered, to sum up



BOARD ALERT

Do not begin every paragraph with a connector. Use them where the logic needs them. Overuse of *moreover* and *furthermore* sounds like a machine.

Openings That Work

TECHNIQUE	EXAMPLE (TOPIC: A RAINY DAY)
Sensory image	The first drop hit the dusty window and the whole street seemed to inhale.
Short, bold statement	Nobody planned for the rain, and that was its charm.
Question	Have you ever heard a city go quiet in the middle of the afternoon?
Dialogue	“Bring the washing in!” Mother shouted, a second too late.
Setting the scene	By four o’clock the sky over our colony had turned the colour of old iron.

Endings That Work

- **Echo the opening.** Return to the image you began with, now changed in meaning.
- **A lesson or realisation.** One crisp sentence, not a sermon.
- **A look ahead.** What will you do, or what should society do?
- **A final image.** Leave the reader with a picture.



HOT QUESTION

HOT: Why is an ending like “So this is my essay on pollution. Thank you” a poor choice, and what could replace it?

Answer: It announces that you are writing, which the examiner already knows, and it adds no thought. Replace it with a closing idea, such as: "Clean air will not arrive by itself; it will arrive the day each of us treats a single tree as our own responsibility."

Model Essay 1: Descriptive

Topic: Describe a village fair as dusk falls.

By late afternoon the maidan outside our village had turned into a small, noisy kingdom. Tents of faded orange and green cloth leaned against one another like tired friends, and from every side came the clang of brass bells, the hiss of hot oil and the crackle of a loudspeaker that had clearly seen better decades.

The food lane was the heart of the fair. Women in bright cotton sarees pressed rounds of dough into sizzling pans, and the smell of fried jalebis drifted so thick that even the dogs sat waiting at a respectful distance. A boy not older than ten balanced a tray of roasted peanuts on his head and shouted their price in a sing-song voice that nobody could resist.

Beyond the stalls stood the giant wheel, creaking at every turn. Its seats were nothing more than painted wooden boxes, yet children queued for them as if they led to the sky. When the wheel stopped at the top, one could see the whole fair spread below, a patchwork of lanterns, umbrellas and swaying heads, and beyond it the fields turning to gold in the last light.

As the sun slid behind the sugarcane, the lamps came on, one by one. Strings of tiny bulbs flickered along the stalls, and the grey dust in the air began to glow like powdered amber. Drummers gathered near the temple wall, and soon a ring of villagers had formed, clapping out a rhythm that rose and fell with the evening breeze.

I stood at the edge of it all with a paper cone of sweets, unable to decide which sense to trust. The colours, the sounds and the smells seemed to overlap, each one adding to the others. When at last I turned homeward, the music followed me down the dark lane, and I understood that a fair is not a place but a feeling that a whole village agrees to share for one evening.

(Word count: about 325)

SIDEKICK TIP

Why it works: every paragraph has one focus (arrival, food, wheel, lights, farewell), it uses all five senses, and the ending turns a scene into an idea.

Model Essay 2: Narrative

Topic: Write a story that begins: "The lights went out just as the results were being announced."

The lights went out just as the results were being announced. A gasp rolled through the school hall, and then silence settled, heavy and total. I was sitting in the third row with sweaty palms, hoping that my name would not be called, because I had entered the science exhibition only on a dare.

It had all begun two months earlier. My cousin Rhea had bet that I could not build a working water purifier from scraps. I had never won an argument with Rhea, so I spent my evenings with a plastic bottle, sand, charcoal and cotton, failing in new ways each night. My father watched from the doorway, saying nothing, which was somehow worse than criticism.

On the day of the exhibition my model leaked. Muddy water dribbled across the table and I felt the eyes of the judges on me. Mrs Dsouza, the chief judge, bent down, dipped her finger into the filtered water and smiled faintly. “It is cleaner than what went in,” she said. “That is all a purifier has to do.” Her words kept me standing till the end.

Now, in the darkness, I heard the principal’s voice, calm and unhurried. “Let us wait,” he said. Someone switched on a mobile torch, then another, and soon the hall glittered with small white stars. In that strange light the principal read the winners aloud from a printed sheet held close to a student’s phone.

“Third prize, Class X-B. Second prize, Class IX-A.” My heart thudded. “First prize, for innovation with limited resources: Kabir Menon, Class X-C.” For a moment I did not understand that the name was mine. Rhea’s elbow dug into my ribs, and the hall erupted in applause as the generator finally hummed and the lights flooded back.

I walked to the stage with legs that did not feel my own. My father stood at the back, and for the first time in two months he was smiling openly. That night I understood that a leaking bottle can still be a beginning, as long as you refuse to stop at the first spill.

(Word count: about 350)



SIDEKICK TIP

Why it works: the given opening line is used exactly, there is a flashback that explains the tension, a turning point (the judge’s remark), a climax, and an ending that carries a meaning.

Model Essay 3: Reflective

Topic: The day I learnt that failure is not final.

I have always thought of failure as a loud word, a red mark on a page or a sentence spoken in a disappointed voice. The day I truly met it, however, was strangely quiet. It happened on a Saturday morning when I stood at the edge of the swimming pool at our district meet and watched the other seven lanes finish before I did.

I had trained for four months. Every morning at five I woke to the sound of my alarm, hated it, and went anyway. My coach, Mr Fernandes, kept repeating one phrase: “Breathe on the third stroke.” In the final race I forgot it. My breathing went wild by the second lap, and I came in last, shivering and ashamed, with water in my ears and nothing else in my mind.

For a week afterwards I avoided the pool, the coach and even the swimming bag in my cupboard. I told myself that I was simply not meant for sport. It was my grandmother who broke that spell. She did not lecture me. She only asked, “Did you finish the race?” When I said yes, she nodded and returned to her knitting as if a great question had been settled.

Her calm question rearranged my thinking. I had finished. I had been brave enough to enter, strong enough to complete the distance, and honest enough to see my mistake. That was a list of things I had gained, yet I had counted only the single thing I had lost.

I went back to the pool the following Monday. Mr Fernandes said nothing about the race; he simply handed me a stopwatch and told me to count my strokes. Slowly, the third-stroke breath became second nature. Within three months I had cut eleven seconds from my best time.

Looking back, I am almost grateful for that last-place finish. It taught me that failure is a pause in the sentence, not the full stop. What follows the pause is entirely up to us.

(Word count: about 334)

SIDEKICK TIP

Why it works: a reflective essay keeps a single story but spends more time on *thoughts and feelings* than on action. The lesson arrives late and sounds earned.

Model Essay 4: Argumentative

Topic: Competitive exams should not decide a student's future. Argue for or against.

Every March, millions of young people sit before an answer sheet as though their entire lives were printed on it. Entrance tests have become the gate to almost every career in India, and while they bring a sense of fairness, I firmly believe they should not be the sole judge of a student's future.

To begin with, a three-hour paper measures only a narrow slice of ability. It can test memory, speed and the knack of eliminating wrong options, but it cannot test patience, creativity or the capacity to work in a team. A student who sketches brilliant ideas or builds a working irrigation model may still lose a seat to someone who has merely practised more mock papers.

Moreover, these exams reward the privileged. Coaching classes cost lakhs, and a family in a small town may not afford them. When two students have equal talent but unequal resources, a test that appears neutral in fact favours the richer one. A system that claims to select merit should not depend on the size of a parent's wallet.

Equally serious is the damage to mental health. Reports of anxiety, sleeplessness and even tragic outcomes among examinees are no longer rare. When a single result can shut a door for years, it is natural that teenagers feel crushed by it.

Supporters argue that, without such tests, admissions would be chaotic and open to favouritism. This is a fair concern, but it can be answered. Universities can combine entrance scores with school performance, project work and interviews, so that no single paper carries the whole burden. Several countries already do so with good results.

In conclusion, examinations are useful as one measuring tool but dangerous as the only one. A fair future for our youth lies in assessing many talents over time, not one skill on one morning. Until we do that, we will keep losing gifted minds to a system that cannot see them.

(Word count: about 322)

SIDEKICK TIP

Why it works: clear stand in the opening, three separate reasons in separate paragraphs, a counter-argument that is answered, and a firm conclusion. Notice the formal tone: no "I feel", no slang.

Model Essay 5: Discursive

Topic: Online learning is better than classroom learning. Discuss both sides.

When schools shut their gates a few years ago, millions of children found themselves learning in front of a glowing screen. Since then, online education has stayed on as a serious companion to the classroom. Is it better? The answer is not a simple yes or no.

The advantages of online learning are real. A student in a remote hill town can attend a lesson delivered by an expert in Delhi. Recorded lectures can be paused, replayed and revised at midnight if needed, which suits slower readers and quicker thinkers alike. Travel time and costs disappear, and interactive tools such as animations make some topics, like planetary motion, easier to grasp than a chalk diagram.

However, the classroom offers things no screen can imitate. A teacher notices the puzzled face at the back and slows down. Friends compare notes in the corridor and learn to share, to disagree and to forgive. Laboratories, sports grounds and school plays teach skills that cannot be downloaded. For young children in particular, the physical presence of a teacher gives a sense of discipline and belonging that a camera does not.

Online learning also brings difficulties of its own. Poor connectivity can interrupt a lesson at the key moment, and not every family owns a device for each child. Long hours of screen time strain the eyes and weaken attention, and it is far easier to switch off the camera and drift away than it is to ignore a teacher standing in front of you.

In my view, the two modes work best together. A blended approach lets technology handle what it does well, such as revision, research and access to distant experts, while the classroom keeps its place for discussion, practical work and personal care. Rather than asking which is better, we should ask which tool suits which task.

To sum up, online learning is a valuable addition but not a replacement. The best education will be the one that borrows the strengths of both.

(Word count: about 331)



SIDEKICK TIP

Why it works: a discursive essay gives each side its own paragraph, then states a personal, balanced view near the end. It does not hammer a single opinion from line one.

Picture-Based Compositions

The paper may show a picture instead of a bare title. The picture is a **trigger**, not a test of art. You may describe it, tell the story behind it or reflect on its idea. Use this routine:

1. Look for three details
People, setting, objects, expressions. Write them in the margin.

2. Ask four questions
Who are they? Where? What just happened? What may happen next?

3. Pick an angle
Descriptive (what I see), narrative (the story), or reflective (what it makes me think).

4. Weave in the details
Mention at least three visible details so the examiner knows you studied the picture.

5. Do not just list
A list of "In the picture I see a boy, a dog, a tree" earns very little. Turn the objects into a scene.

REAL LIFE

Example angle: picture of a child holding an umbrella over a stray puppy in heavy rain. Narrative: a boy's walk home becomes a rescue. Reflective: small kindness. Argumentative: should stray animals be cared for by the community?

Mistakes That Cost Marks

MISTAKE	FIX
Memorised essay forced into the topic	Rebuild the opening and every example to match the exact words of the question
Informal words (kids, guys, a lot of)	Use children, people, many; keep the tone formal for argumentative pieces
Tense slips in narration	Pick the past tense and hold it; only dialogue may shift
Comma splices: "It rained, we stayed home."	Join with a conjunction or use a full stop
Short, choppy sentences throughout	Combine with who, which, although, when
No paragraphs	Begin a new paragraph for every new idea; leave a clear gap
Spelling slips: recieve, definately, seperate	Write receive, definitely, separate; keep a list of your own errors
Abrupt end	Reserve the last five minutes for the ending and a quick proofread

BOARD ALERT

Board alert: a composition that has little connection with the chosen topic is marked low on content, however well written. Reread the topic before you write your ending.

Recap

- Read all topics, choose by how many points you can find, then plan for five minutes.
- Use five paragraphs: opening, three developing paragraphs, ending. Target about 320 words.
- The type of composition decides tone and tense; the topic's keywords tell you the type.
- Link paragraphs with connectors, but do not overuse them.
- Begin with a hook, end with a thought, and proofread for tense, spelling and punctuation.

Practice

Write a plan (not the full essay) for each topic. Then pick one and write it in 320 words in 35 minutes.

- Describe the market of your town on the eve of a festival. *(descriptive)*

- Write a story that ends with the words: "...and that was the last time I ever doubted her." *(narrative)*
- A person who has changed the way I think. *(reflective)*
- Social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Do you agree? *(argumentative)*
- Should schools make community service compulsory? Discuss both sides. *(discursive)*
- Write on the picture of an empty classroom with one lit lamp on the teacher's desk. *(picture-based)*



KEY POINT

Self-check list after writing: Did I answer this exact topic? Does each paragraph have one idea? Is my tense steady? Are there at least three linking words? Does my ending add a thought? Is the length between 300 and 350?

02

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Letter Writing

Question 2 gives you a choice of two letters: one formal, one friendly. Marks go to the content, but also to the format, the tone and the vocabulary. Get the layout right and you already hold half the marks.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Formal vs informal
- Layouts
- Opening and closing lines
- Tone and vocabulary
- Model letters
- Practice with hints

Two Kinds of Letter

FEATURE	FORMAL LETTER	INFORMAL (FRIENDLY) LETTER
Addressed to	Principal, editor, officer, manager, authority	Friend, cousin, sibling, relative
Purpose	Complaint, request, application, enquiry, opinion	Share news, invite, congratulate, advise, console
Tone	Polite, precise, impersonal	Warm, natural, personal
Language	No contractions or slang; full forms	Contractions allowed; simple, chatty
Salutation	Sir / Madam / Dear Sir	Dear Aarav / Dear Meera
Subject line	Required	Not used
Closing	Yours faithfully / Yours sincerely	Your loving friend / Yours affectionately

The Format of a Formal Letter

Follow this order every time. Examiners notice a missing element at once.

1. Sender's address and date
Top right (or left in block style). Write the address on separate lines, then the date below.

2. Receiver's designation and address
On the left. Begin with the post: The Editor, The Manager, The Principal.

3. Salutation
Sir / Madam, or Dear Sir / Dear Madam. Add a comma.

4. Subject line
A short, specific heading, often underlined: Subject: Complaint about irregular garbage collection in Sector 9.

5. Body
Three short paragraphs: reason for writing, details, request or expected action.

6. Complimentary close and signature
Yours faithfully if you began with Sir or Madam. Yours sincerely if you used the person's name. Then your name below.



KEY POINT

Rule of thumb: Dear Sir / Madam → **Yours faithfully**. Dear Mr Rao → **Yours sincerely**. In the ICSE paper, you will usually be given the name only through the instructions, so Sir / Madam and Yours faithfully are the safe pair.

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                                Flat 12, Orchid Apartments,
                                Green Park Road,
                                Pune - 411 007.
                                14 March 2027

The Municipal Commissioner,
Pune Municipal Corporation,
Pune - 411 001.

Sir,

Subject: Request for repair of street lights on Green Park Road

[Paragraph 1: why you write]
[Paragraph 2: details, effect, dates]
[Paragraph 3: request, thanks]

Yours faithfully,
Riya Kulkarni
```



SIDEKICK TIP

Use the address and name given in the question. If the question does not give your address, you may invent a suitable one. Do not write your own real name or school; use the one provided or a neutral name such as *Rohit Sharma*, or the signature "Sd/- X" if instructed.

The Format of an Informal Letter

- Your address and date at top right. No receiver's address.
- Salutation: **Dear Kabir,**
- Open with a warm line: "I hope you are doing well. It was lovely to get your last letter."
- Body in two or three paragraphs. Add feelings, small details and a question or two back to the friend.
- Close with a line such as "Write soon and tell me everything," then **Yours affectionately / Your loving friend,** and your first name.

Tone and Vocabulary at a Glance

SAY THIS IN A FORMAL LETTER	NOT THIS
I wish to bring to your notice	I want to tell you
I would be grateful if you could	Please do it quickly
The matter requires immediate attention	This is a big problem
I regret to inform you	I am sorry to say
Kindly look into the matter	Do something about it
I remain at your disposal for any clarification	Call me if you need



BOARD ALERT

Board alert: never start a formal letter with “I hope you are fine.” Go straight to the reason in the first line. Do not end it with “Bye” or “Love”.

Types of Formal Letters

1. Letter of Complaint

- State what you bought or experienced, with date and place.
- Describe the fault precisely: number, amount, duration.
- Say what you expect: refund, repair, replacement, action.
- End politely but firmly, with a time limit if suitable.

2. Letter to the Editor

- Address: The Editor, [Newspaper name], [City].
- Subject line states the issue.
- Write for the public good: describe the problem, its causes, its effect on people, and a suggested solution.
- Request that the letter be published.

3. Letter of Request or Application

- Say who you are and what you request.
- Give reasons in a clear order.
- Offer to provide documents or follow-up.
- Thank the reader in advance.

4. Letter of Enquiry or Order

- Ask for details such as price, dates, discounts, availability.
- For an order, list items with quantity and mention payment and delivery.

Model Formal Letter 1: Complaint

You bought a pair of headphones from an online store, but a defective unit was delivered. Write to the customer care manager.

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                                B-21, Lake View Colony,
                                Bhopal - 462 003.
                                9 August 2027

The Customer Care Manager,
SoundNest Online Pvt. Ltd.,
Bengaluru - 560 001.

Sir,

Subject: Complaint regarding defective headphones, Order No. SN4821

I placed an order for a pair of wireless headphones (Order No. SN4821) on your website on 28 July 202

The right earpiece produces no sound at all, and the left one crackles each time the volume goes above

I request you to replace the headphones with a working piece or refund the amount of Rs 2,499 within s

Yours faithfully,
Vikram Joshi
```

Model Formal Letter 2: Letter to the Editor

Write to the editor of a daily about the increasing noise from loudspeakers during board examination months.

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                                27, Shanti Nagar,
                                Jaipur - 302 004.
                                3 February 2027

The Editor,
The Daily Chronicle,
Jaipur - 302 001.

Sir,

Subject: Loudspeaker noise during the examination season

Through the columns of your esteemed newspaper, I wish to draw the attention of the authorities to a p

From February onwards, weddings, rallies and religious gatherings in our city use loudspeakers late in

I urge the police and the pollution control board to monitor these limits strictly during the examinat

I hope you will publish this letter so that it may reach those who can act.

Yours faithfully,
Neha Agarwal
```

Model Informal Letter: Advice to a Friend

Your friend has lost confidence after a poor result in a unit test. Write a letter to cheer them up and offer advice.

```
                                H-4, Sunrise Society,
                                Nagpur - 440 010.
                                21 September 2027

Dear Tanvi,

I got your letter yesterday and read it twice. I am sorry that the maths test did not go as you had ho

Do you remember how you struggled with swimming in Class VII and then won the inter-house race the nex

Here is what worked for me when I was in a similar spot. Sit with your corrected paper and list every

I am free this Sunday afternoon, so why don't I come over and we can work on the problems together? Br

Chin up, and write to me soon.

Your loving friend,
Sneha
```

Model Informal Letter: Invitation

Invite your cousin to spend the winter holidays with you and describe the plans you have made.

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                                45, Hill View Road,
                                Shimla - 171 001.
                                5 December 2027

Dear Arjun,

Guess what? Our school closes on 20 December, and Mother has agreed that you can stay with us for the

It has already begun to turn cold here, and the forecasters say we may get snow before Christmas. I ha

Bring your guitar and your thickest jacket. Grandmother is already knitting you a muffler, so you have

Let me know your train and I shall be at the station to receive you.

Yours affectionately,
Dev
```

How to Plan in Three Minutes

1. Decide the type
Formal or informal? Who is the reader?

2. Jot three points
The question often gives hints: use all of them, in the given order or a logical one.

3. Check format
Address, date, salutation, subject (formal only), close, signature.

4. Write 150 to 200 words
Short, clear paragraphs. Do not run past the page.



HOT QUESTION

HOT: You are asked to write to the Principal asking permission to hold a charity book fair. Which three details would make the request convincing, and how will you phrase the closing line?

Answer: (1) Purpose and beneficiary of the fair, (2) proposed date, venue and time without disturbing classes, (3) how books will be collected and funds handed over. Closing: "I assure you that the event will be conducted with full discipline, and I shall be grateful for your kind permission."

Common Mistakes

MISTAKE	CORRECTION
"Your's faithfully"	Yours faithfully (no apostrophe)
Sir, ... Yours sincerely	Sir, ... Yours faithfully
Writing a subject line in an informal letter	Omit it
Sender's address placed on the left, or signature missing	Address top right, signature and name at the bottom
Long, heavy opening	Get to the purpose in the first two lines
Using "etc." and "&" in the body	Write in full
Different tone inside the letter	Choose a tone and stay with it

Recap

- Formal letter: sender's address, date, receiver, salutation, subject, body (3 paragraphs), close, signature.
- Informal letter: address, date, salutation, warm body, affectionate close.
- Sir/Madam goes with Yours faithfully. Dear + name goes with Yours sincerely.
- Use all hints given in the question; add fresh, believable details.
- Tone and vocabulary are marked separately from content.

Practice

Write each letter in 150 to 200 words, with proper format.

- **Formal:** Write to the Principal requesting a day off the timetable to hold a blood donation camp. Mention the date, the partner hospital and how students above 18 will be involved.
- **Formal:** Write to the Station Master of your local railway station complaining about the lack of drinking water and clean waiting rooms. Suggest remedies.
- **Formal:** Write to the Editor on the dangers of speeding by two-wheelers near your school, and propose speed breakers and traffic wardens.
- **Formal:** You ordered five books from a publisher but received only three. Write to the Sales Manager asking for the rest.
- **Informal:** Write to a friend abroad describing how you celebrated a festival this year and asking about the festivals where they live.
- **Informal:** Your younger brother is addicted to video games. Write to him with gentle advice and suggest alternatives.
- **Informal:** Congratulate a friend who has won a state-level debate and ask about the experience.



SIDEKICK TIP

Model answers: compare your letter with the models above for layout. Content will differ, and that is what we want: the examiner rewards *your* relevant details.

03

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Notice and E-mail Writing

Question 3 gives you one situation and asks for two short pieces: a notice (part a) and an e-mail on the same content (part b). Both are quick marks if you know the format and keep every detail from the question.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Notice format
- 50-word rule
- E-mail format
- Notice vs e-mail
- Model pairs
- Practice

Why This Question Is a Gift

The content is supplied in the question, so you do not need to invent ideas. The marks lie in **format, completeness, brevity and correct language**. A notice is typically written within 50 words; the e-mail is a little fuller, around 100 to 120 words.

Part (a): The Notice

A notice is a public, one-way message. It informs a group of readers of an event, rule or change. It must be understood in a single reading.

1. Name of the issuing body
School, society, club or institution, at the top and centred, usually in capitals.

2. The word NOTICE
Centred, in capitals, below the name. Some boxes it.

3. Date
Left or right, below. Write it in full: 12 August 2027.

4. Heading
One line stating the subject, in capitals or underlined.

5. Body
Say what, when, where and who. Add instructions, deadlines or conditions.

6. Signatory
Name and designation of the person issuing the notice (Secretary, Principal, Head Boy). Placed at the bottom left or right.



KEY POINT

Checklist for every notice: What is happening? When (date and time)? Where? Who may or must attend? What should they bring or do? Whom to contact? Include every item the question mentions.



SIDEKICK TIP

Write in the **third person or impersonal** style. Use phrases such as “All students are informed that...”, “Interested students may...” and “The last date for registration is...”. Never use “I”.



BOARD ALERT

Board alert: do not sign with your own name if the question says “You are the Cultural Secretary”. Write the designation as given. Do not exceed the word limit; a 120-word notice loses marks for style.

Model Notice 1: An Event

Your school is organising an inter-class poster-making contest on Water Conservation. As the Art Club Secretary, write a notice.

```
              ST. THOMAS SENIOR SECONDARY SCHOOL, KOCHI
                              NOTICE

12 August 2027

            INTER-CLASS POSTER-MAKING CONTEST

The Art Club announces a poster-making contest on the theme
“Save Every Drop” for Classes VIII to X on Friday, 27 August,
from 10 a.m. to 12 noon in the Art Room. Each class may send
three participants. Drawing sheets will be provided; students
should bring their own colours. Names must reach the Art
Club by 20 August.

                                          Anjali Menon
                                          Secretary, Art Club
```

Model Notice 2: A Change or Cancellation

The annual sports day has been postponed because of the forecast of heavy rain. You are the Sports Captain. Write a notice.

```
                DELHI HERITAGE PUBLIC SCHOOL
                          NOTICE

3 November 2027

                  SPORTS DAY POSTPONED

All students are informed that the Annual Sports Day, fixed
for 8 November, stands postponed due to the forecast of heavy
rain. The event will now be held on Saturday, 13 November, at
9 a.m. in the school ground. Participants should report to
their house masters by 8.30 a.m. Entry passes already issued
remain valid.

                                          Kunal Bhatia
                                          Sports Captain
```

Part (b): The E-mail

An e-mail is a message sent electronically to one or more named people. It is half-way between a letter and a note: brief but polite. When the question says “write an e-mail on the same content”, you convert the notice information into a message addressed to a person.

PART	WHAT GOES THERE	EXAMPLE
From	Sender's e-mail address	art.club@stthomas.edu
To	Recipient's e-mail address	class10b@stthomas.edu
Cc / Bcc	Others who get a copy (optional)	principal@stthomas.edu
Subject	A short, clear phrase (about 5 to 8 words)	Poster contest on 27 August
Salutation	Dear + name or group	Dear Students,
Body	Purpose, details, action needed	2 short paragraphs
Closing	Regards / Yours sincerely	With regards,
Name and designation	Below the closing	Anjali Menon, Secretary, Art Club



SIDEKICK TIP

Use **Dear Sir/Madam** if you do not know the person's name. For a known audience, "Dear Students" or "Dear All" is fine. In ICSE e-mails, always include the From, To and Subject fields, even if the question only gives you part of the information. Make up a suitable address.

Notice vs E-mail at a Glance

FEATURE	NOTICE	E-MAIL
Audience	General, many readers	Named person or group
Heading	Event or subject, centred	Subject line
Opening	None; goes direct to the point	Dear + name
Voice	Impersonal	Polite, can be slightly personal
Length	About 50 words	About 100 to 120 words
Sign-off	Name and designation	Closing phrase, name and designation
Fields	Name of body, NOTICE, date	From, To, Cc, Subject

Model E-mail for Notice 1

```
From   : art.club@stthomas.edu
To     : class8to10@stthomas.edu
Cc     : principal@stthomas.edu
Subject: Inter-class poster contest on 27 August

Dear Students,

I am happy to inform you that the Art Club is organising an
inter-class poster-making contest on the theme “Save Every
Drop”. It will be held on Friday, 27 August, from 10 a.m. to
12 noon in the Art Room, and is open to students of Classes
VIII to X.

Each class may send three participants. We shall provide the
drawing sheets, but please bring your own colours. Kindly send
the names of your participants to the Art Club on or before
20 August. For any doubts, you may reach me at the e-mail
address above.

We look forward to your enthusiastic participation.

With regards,
Anjali Menon
Secretary, Art Club
```

Model E-mail for Notice 2

```
From   : sports.captain@dhps.edu
To     : allstudents@dhps.edu
Subject: Sports Day postponed to 13 November

Dear All,

The Annual Sports Day, which was scheduled for 8 November,
has been postponed because the weather office has forecast
heavy rain on that day.

The new date is Saturday, 13 November. The event will start
at 9 a.m. in the school ground. All participants should report
to their house masters by 8.30 a.m. The entry passes already
issued will remain valid, so there is no need to collect fresh
ones.

Please inform your parents about the change and prepare well.

Yours sincerely,
Kunal Bhatia
Sports Captain
```

Types of Situations and What to Include

SITUATION	MUST-HAVE DETAILS
Event, competition, workshop	Name, date, time, venue, eligibility, last date, contact
Lost and found	Item, description, place and time, whom to contact, reward if any
Change or cancellation	What changed, old date, new date, reason, instructions
Appeal or drive (blood donation, cleanliness)	Purpose, date, place, who can take part, what to bring
Meeting or assembly	Agenda, date, time, venue, who must attend
Admission or enrolment	Course, eligibility, fees, last date, procedure



HOT QUESTION

HOT: A friend's notice says: "I am glad to tell you that there will be a quiz tomorrow. Everyone must come." List three errors in this notice.

Answer: (1) No heading, name of the institution or date. (2) The first-person voice ("I am glad to tell you") is unsuitable for a notice. (3) Vital details are missing: time, venue, topic, last date for names, and the issuer's name and designation. "Tomorrow" should also be replaced with the actual date.

Common Mistakes

- Missing the date, venue, or time, which examiners check first.
- Notice written in letter form, with a salutation and "Yours sincerely".
- E-mail without a subject line.
- Copying the notice word for word into the e-mail. Rewrite it in the e-mail voice.
- Ending the e-mail with "Love" or "Bye". Use Regards or Yours sincerely.

Recap

- Notice: body name, NOTICE, date, heading, body, signatory. Impersonal and under 50 words.
- E-mail: From, To, (Cc), Subject, salutation, body, closing, name and designation. 100 to 120 words.
- Every detail in the question must appear in both pieces.
- Answer part (a) first. Part (b) reuses the facts but changes the voice.

Practice

For each situation, write the notice (under 50 words) and the e-mail (about 100 words).

- You are the Head Girl. A career-guidance talk by a former student, now a doctor, is to be held for Class X on 5 October at 11 a.m. in the school auditorium. Students must bring a notebook and register with the class

teacher by 1 October.

- You are the Secretary of the Eco Club. The club plans a tree-planting drive on 15 July at 7.30 a.m. near the school boundary wall. Volunteers should bring gloves and a water bottle and meet near the main gate.
- You are the school librarian. The library will remain closed from 18 to 22 December for stock-checking. Books borrowed earlier must be returned by 16 December.
- You found a blue water bottle with the initials A.K. near the basketball court. Write a notice for the school board and an e-mail to the Class X group.



SIDEKICK TIP

Self-check: does your notice have a heading, the date, all the facts, and a signatory? Does your e-mail have a subject, a salutation and a courteous close?

04

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Unseen Passage: Comprehension, Vocabulary and Summary

Question 4 tests four skills on one passage of about 500 words: vocabulary in context, short-answer comprehension, inference, and a summary. This chapter gives you a method for each skill and two new passages with fully worked answers.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Reading method
- Vocabulary in context
- Inference
- Summary writing
- Two worked passages
- Practice

What the Paper Asks

PART	WHAT IT TESTS	TYPICAL WORDING
Vocabulary	Meaning of words or phrases as used in the passage	Choose any four words and use them so as to bring out the meaning clearly / Give a word or phrase from the passage that means...
Short answers	Explicit facts, organisation, inference about intention and attitude	Why did the author...? What does the phrase suggest about...?
Summary	Main ideas separated from details, rewritten in a given length	In about 80 words, summarise what the passage says about...



KEY POINT

The summary question tells you **exactly what to summarise** and **how long**. Read the instruction before you read the passage, so you can underline relevant lines on the first reading.

A Four-Step Reading Method

1. Preview (1 min)
Read the title and the questions first. Know what you are hunting for.

2. Read (4 min)
Read the passage once, steadily. Underline names, dates, reasons and the writer's opinion.

3. Answer in order (20 min)
Questions mostly follow the order of the passage. Go back to the line for each answer.

4. Summarise last (10 min)
Use the key lines underlined on your first read. Write a rough version, then trim.

Writing Short Answers

- **Answer the question asked.** If it says "why", your answer begins with a reason.
- **Use your own words** where possible, but do not distort facts. For explicit questions, a short phrase lifted from the passage is acceptable when it fits grammatically.
- **Match length to marks.** One mark: one phrase or sentence. Two marks: two points or one point with explanation.
- **Write a complete sentence** unless the question asks for a word or phrase.
- **For inference questions**, give the idea and the textual clue that supports it.

Vocabulary in Context

The examiner wants to see that you grasp the meaning **as used here**. The best way to prove it is to write a sentence that makes the meaning obvious.

WEAK SENTENCE	BETTER SENTENCE	WHY
He was reluctant.	He was reluctant to leave the warm bed on that freezing morning.	The clue shows he did not want to go
It was a fragile vase.	The fragile vase shattered when the child brushed against the table.	Shows it breaks easily
She was bitter.	She was bitter about the unfair decision and refused to speak to the judges.	Shows resentment



SIDEKICK TIP

If a word is unfamiliar, test three things: (1) the sentence around it, (2) the words that sit near it, such as *but* or *and* which signal contrast or addition, and (3) its roots or parts (*un-, re-, -ful, -less*).

Inference: Reading Between the Lines

An inference is a conclusion the writer does not state directly but makes you feel. The passage will give clues in the choice of words, the details selected, or the tone.

LINE IN A PASSAGE	POSSIBLE INFERENCE
“Rohan’s eyes flicked to the clock for the fifth time.”	He is impatient or anxious.
“The hall emptied fast; the lights were off before she finished the last line.”	Her speech did not hold the audience, or no one cared.
“He ate the dry bread as if it were a banquet.”	He is very hungry or very poor.

Summary Writing

1. Find the main points
Underline the ideas that answer the exact topic of the summary. Ignore examples, dates and dialogue unless they are essential.

2. Note-making
List the points in your own order in short phrases. Aim for as many points as you have marks.

3. Draft
Join the points into a single paragraph with linking words. Use your own words. Do not copy long phrases.

4. Count and trim
The limit is usually 70 to 90 words. Remove adjectives and repeated ideas.

5. Check
Past tense for events, present for general truths. No opinions of your own, no quotations.

BOARD ALERT

Board alert: a summary with the heading “Summary” and 20 lines of unconnected phrases will lose marks. Write one flowing paragraph. Do not exceed the word limit by more than a few words.

Passage 1

The Last Postman of Kalimpong Hill

When Dorje Tamang began his career as a postman, the hill road to Rimbik was little more than a goat track. He carried his canvas bag across three streams and a landslide scar, and in every season the villagers knew him by the sound of his bicycle bell. Letters, in those days, were rare treasures. A mother waited months for news from a soldier son; a bride waited weeks for her father’s blessing. Dorje understood that he was not delivering paper but hope, and he treated each envelope like a fragile egg.

Over thirty-four years he came to know every family on his route. He knew which grandmother could not read and needed him to read her letters aloud, and which shopkeeper pretended not to care about his daughter’s school results but asked him twice about them. Sometimes he stayed for tea, and sometimes he carried a message back without being asked. The hill people said that Dorje delivered news in both directions. Once, during a winter storm, he carried a sack of medicine across a swollen stream on his shoulders because a village clinic was waiting for it, and nobody on the hill ever forgot that morning. Courage, for him, was simply part of the job.

Then the world changed. Mobile phones arrived, first in the valley and then on the ridge, and the volume of letters began to shrink. People now sent photographs in an instant and spoke to relatives in another country as though they were in the next room. The post office in Kalimpong, which once sorted three hundred letters a day, handled thirty. The department spoke of closing the rural route.

Dorje was not bitter. He admitted that the new devices were wonderful, especially the day his own son, working in Pune, phoned to say that he had been promoted. Yet he also noticed what had been lost. “A voice fades the moment the call ends,” he told a young reporter. “A letter stays. Open the old tin box in my house and you will find my wife’s handwriting from forty years ago. Can a message on a screen last that long?”

The reporter’s article spread quickly. Within weeks, schoolchildren across the state began writing to the hill villages, and students in the villages wrote back. A campaign called “Write One Letter” brought bundles of mail to Rimbik. Parents who had not held a pen in years joined in as well. Teachers said that children who had struggled to form a paragraph now took pride in a full page, with a stamp and a postmark.

The department decided to keep the route open. Dorje retired a year later, but he did not stop walking. Each Sunday he can still be seen on the old path, bag on shoulder, taking letters to those who cannot climb to the post office. When asked why, he smiles. “Machines carry words,” he says. “People carry feelings. Someone has to do both.”

(About 500 words)

Questions

(a) Why did Dorje Tamang handle every envelope “like a fragile egg”? *(2)*

(b) What did the hill people mean when they said Dorje “delivered news in both directions”? *(2)*

(c) How did mobile phones affect the Kalimpong post office? *(2)*

(d) Why did Dorje say that “a letter stays”? *(2)*

(e) What made the department change its mind about closing the route? *(2)*

(f) From the passage, what can you infer about Dorje's attitude to technology? Support your answer. *(2)*

(g) Choose four of the following words and use each in a sentence of your own to bring out its meaning. *(4)*
treasures, fragile, bitter, campaign, retired, pride

(h) In about 80 words, summarise how Dorje's work and the way people viewed it changed from his early days to his retirement. *(8)*

Model Answers

- **(a)** He realised that he was bringing hope to families waiting for news from far away. For them a letter meant a loved one's message, so it deserved the same care as something that could break easily.
- **(b)** It means that he carried letters to the villagers and also took their replies and messages back, acting as a link between people and not merely as an official who dropped mail.
- **(c)** The number of letters fell sharply. The post office, which used to sort about three hundred letters daily, now handled only thirty, and the department even talked of closing the rural route.
- **(d)** A voice or a call disappears when it ends, but a written letter can be kept for years. He had his wife's letters from forty years earlier in a tin box, which shows how lasting a letter is.
- **(e)** A reporter's article led children across the state to write letters to hill villages through the "Write One Letter" campaign. The sudden rise in mail made the department keep the route open.
- **(f)** He is not against technology, since he praises it as "wonderful" and welcomed the call from his promoted son. Yet he values the lasting, personal quality of letters and feels that both can exist together.
- **(g)** *treasures*: Old photographs and letters were the treasures she guarded in her cupboard. *fragile*: The fragile glass cracked at the slightest touch. *bitter*: He grew bitter after being blamed for a mistake he did not make. *campaign*: The school started a campaign to collect old books for village libraries. (Any four suitable sentences.)

Model Summary (about 80 words)

Dorje Tamang began as a postman on a hard hill route, where letters were precious and he treated them with great care. He knew each family and carried news both ways. When mobile phones reduced the mail, the department thought of closing the route. Dorje accepted the new devices but defended letters for their permanence. A reporter's story inspired a letter-writing campaign that revived the route. He retired, yet still delivers letters voluntarily, believing that people must carry feelings too.



SIDEKICK TIP

Why this summary works: it follows the passage in time order (early days, change, revival, retirement), each sentence carries one point, no quotes, no examples such as the tin box, and the length is within range.



HOT QUESTION

HOT: The last line says, "Machines carry words. People carry feelings." Do you agree that technology cannot carry feeling? Give two reasons in about 50 words.

Sample: Partly. Machines can convey words and even images instantly, but feelings need a human context. A video call can show a smile, yet it cannot replace the effort of a hand-written note that shows time and thought. Still, a tender voice message can comfort someone far away, so technology can carry feeling when people choose to use it with care.

Passage 2

Stepwells: Palaces Built Downward

In the dry plains of Rajasthan and Gujarat, where rain arrives rarely and rivers run only part of the year, people once dug into the earth to meet the water. The structures they created, called stepwells, are not mere holes in the ground. They are descending staircases of stone, sometimes seven storeys deep, with pillars, carved balconies and galleries that rival any palace above ground.

The idea behind a stepwell was simple but clever. In the monsoon, the pit filled with water, and in summer the water sank lower. Because the steps ran all the way down, a villager could walk to the water level in any season, without a rope or a bucket. Women came in the early morning to fill their pots and exchange gossip, and the cool air at the bottom made it a favourite place to rest during the hottest hours. On festival days, families even gathered in the shaded galleries to sing, eat and share the news of the season. In this way a stepwell served both as a water source and as a social centre.

The builders were also skilled engineers. They chose sites where the water table was high and aligned the structure so that the sun lit the upper levels at midday while the lower levels stayed in shade. The deeper parts of the well could be as much as ten degrees cooler than the surface, which made them a refuge for travellers. Many wells also had shrines at the entrance, as water was regarded as sacred, and rulers and wealthy women often paid for their construction as an act of charity.

Chand Baori, in the village of Abhaneri, is one of the most striking examples. Its thirteen levels fall about thirty metres, with triangular flights of steps forming a pattern on three sides. Visitors say that standing at the edge, one has the odd feeling of looking into an upside-down pyramid.

With the coming of pipes and borewells, stepwells were abandoned. Garbage filled many of them, and others were simply forgotten. By the late twentieth century, a number of these monuments lay in ruins, and some had even been covered over to make car parks. Local residents saw no value in structures that no longer served a purpose.

In recent years, however, there has been a change of attitude. Conservation groups have cleaned and repaired several stepwells, and historians have begun to record their designs. Interestingly, engineers have started to study them for lessons in water harvesting. The ancient method of collecting rainwater and storing it underground suits regions that now face water shortages. Tourists too have helped by visiting and paying entry fees that fund repairs.

A stepwell teaches us that beauty and usefulness need not be separate. Our ancestors did not hide their water supply in a pipe; they honoured it with art. Perhaps the real lesson is that a community that respects its water will protect it for centuries.

(About 500 words)

Questions

(a) Why is a stepwell described as a “palace built downward”? *(2)*

(b) How could villagers reach the water in every season? *(2)*

(c) Mention two ways in which stepwells served the community besides providing water. *(2)*

(d) What does the writer mean by saying the builders were “skilled engineers”? Give two pieces of evidence. *(2)*

(e) Why were stepwells abandoned, and what happened to them afterwards? *(2)*

(f) What recent developments show that attitudes to stepwells are changing? *(2)*

(g) Pick out words or phrases from the passage which mean the same as: *(4)* **(i)** impressive and attention-catching; **(ii)** a place of safety; **(iii)** protection of the environment and heritage; **(iv)** treated with great respect.

(h) In about 80 words, summarise the features and uses of stepwells and the efforts to save them today. *(8)*

Model Answers

- **(a)** Because a stepwell goes deep into the ground instead of rising upwards, yet it has pillars, carved balconies and galleries as grand as those of a palace.
- **(b)** The steps ran all the way down to the water, so people could simply walk to whatever level the water had reached in each season. They needed no rope or bucket.
- **(c)** It was a place where women met and exchanged gossip, and the cool lower levels gave rest to villagers and travellers. (Shrines at the entrance made it a religious site too.)
- **(d)** They picked sites with a high water table and arranged the structure so that light reached the upper levels at noon while the lower levels stayed shaded, making the depths up to ten degrees cooler.
- **(e)** After pipes and borewells arrived, stepwells were no longer needed. Many were filled with garbage or forgotten, and a few were covered to build car parks.
- **(f)** Conservation groups have cleaned and repaired several wells, historians are recording their designs, engineers study them for water harvesting, and tourist fees help pay for repairs.
- **(g)** (i) striking; (ii) refuge; (iii) conservation; (iv) honoured.

Model Summary (about 80 words)

Stepwells are deep, richly carved stone staircases built in dry parts of India to reach water in every season. They also served as cool resting places and meeting spots, and often had shrines. Their builders chose sites carefully for water and shade. After modern pipes appeared, many wells were neglected or destroyed. Today, repair groups, historians, engineers and tourists are helping to preserve them, because their water-harvesting methods are useful and their beauty reminds us to respect water.



REAL LIFE

Notice how both model summaries keep to the **exact focus** the question asked. Passage 2's summary leaves out the Chand Baori description because the question does not ask for examples.

Common Mistakes in Question 4

MISTAKE	FIX
Copying whole lines from the passage	Rewrite the idea in your own words, keeping key words only
Answering with the wrong tense or person	Follow the question; use third person when summarising
Vocabulary sentence that does not show meaning	Add a clue: "She was exhausted, so she fell asleep at once."
Summary that is a shortened copy	Pick main ideas, drop examples, combine sentences
Too long a summary	Keep within about 10% of the limit
No inference clue	Quote or refer to the phrase that led you to the inference

Recap

- Read the questions before you read the passage.
- Underline names, reasons and the writer's tone during the first reading.
- Prove vocabulary by using each word with a clear context clue.
- Inference needs a conclusion plus a clue from the text.
- The summary is one paragraph, in your own words, within the limit, focused on the exact topic.

Practice Passage

The Midnight Library

In my grandfather's house there was a small room at the end of the corridor which we were forbidden to enter after dark. It was not a dangerous room. It was simply his study, a cramped space stacked to the ceiling with books on history, travel and astronomy. He read there every night after the house fell silent, and he believed that the best thoughts arrived only when the clock struck twelve.

One monsoon night, unable to sleep because of the thunder, I crept down the corridor and saw a thin line of light under his door. I pushed it open. He did not scold me. Instead he lifted an old atlas from the pile and made space beside him. "Choose a country," he said. I picked Peru, and for the next hour he described a lost city on a mountain and a bridge made of grass. I had never heard such stories in a classroom.

After that night I went to the study often. He never forced me to read; he only asked questions, and the questions sent me back to the shelves. By the end of that year I had finished more books than in the five years before. When my grandfather passed away, I inherited his collection, and with it his habit. Even now, when the house is silent and the clock strikes twelve, I open a book and feel him quietly turning the page beside me.

- Why were the children not allowed in the study after dark? *(1)*
- What does the phrase "made space beside him" suggest about the grandfather's attitude? *(2)*
- How did the grandfather influence the narrator's reading? *(2)*
- Explain in your own words the meaning of the last sentence. *(2)*
- Summarise the passage in 40 words. *(4)*



SIDEKICK TIP

Hints: (1) Not because of danger, but because he wanted to read in peace. (2) Welcoming, affectionate. (3) By asking questions that sent the child to the books. (4) The narrator still feels the grandfather's presence while reading at midnight. (5) Cover: the study, the monsoon night visit, questions leading to reading, the inherited habit.

05

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Functional Grammar I: Prepositions, Conjunctions and Verbs

Question 5 is a set of short, compulsory items that test how well you can use grammar: prepositions, conjunctions, verbs and sentence structure. This first part covers the three word-level topics, with rules, traps and drills.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Prepositions
- Conjunctions
- Tenses
- Subject-verb agreement
- Modals and conditionals
- Drills with answers

How Question 5 Works

The paper mixes tasks such as filling blanks with prepositions, joining sentences with conjunctions or connectors, supplying the correct form of a verb, and rewriting sentences. Each item is small, but together they carry a big share of the marks, and every item is compulsory.



SIDEKICK TIP

Treat each blank as a mini-puzzle. Read the **whole sentence** first, spot the clue (time word, noun before the blank, a second verb) and only then decide.

Prepositions

A preposition shows how a noun or pronoun relates to another word in the sentence: place, time, direction, reason or means. It almost always comes **before** its object.

Time: at, on, in

USE	PREPOSITION	EXAMPLES
Exact time, festivals	**at**	at 6 o'clock, at noon, at night, at Diwali
Days and dates	**on**	on Monday, on 15 August, on my birthday
Months, years, seasons, long periods	**in**	in March, in 1998, in winter, in the morning
Duration up to a point	**by, until, till**	finish by Friday (not later), wait until Friday (up to then)
Length of time	**for, since, during**	for two hours; since 2019; during the holidays

Place and direction

PREPOSITION	IDEA	EXAMPLE
at	a point or place of activity	at the bus stop, at school
in	inside an area or enclosed space	in the room, in Kerala
on	touching a surface	on the table, on the wall
to	movement towards	walked to the shop
into	movement from outside to inside	jumped into the lake
between / among	two / more than two	between you and me; among the crowd
beside / besides	next to / in addition to	sat beside her; besides English, he knows French
over / above / under / below	higher or lower	a bridge over the river; a fan above the bed

Dependent prepositions: words that must travel together

WORD	TAKES	WORD	TAKES
accuse	of	interested	in
afraid	of	jealous	of
agree	with (a person); to (a plan)	keen	on
angry	with (a person); at / about (a thing)	laugh	at
apologise	to someone for something	listen	to
good / poor / weak	at	prefer	to
aware	of	proud	of
capable	of	result	in / from
comply	with	responsible	for
congratulate	on	suffer	from
depend	on	succeed	in
different	from	wait	for
die	of (disease); from (injury)	provide	with / for

BOARD ALERT

Common traps: *discuss* takes no preposition (We discussed the plan, not "discussed about"). *Enter* a room (not "enter into" in the sense of going in). *Reach* Delhi (not "reach to"). Similarly: *marry* someone, *attend* a meeting, *resemble* her.

Drill 1: Prepositions

Fill each blank with a suitable preposition.

- 1. The train will arrive _____ platform number four _____ 5.40 p.m.
- 2. She has been learning the violin _____ 2022.
- 3. The principal congratulated the team _____ their victory.
- 4. My brother is very keen _____ astronomy.
- 5. The thieves entered the house _____ the back window.
- 6. I prefer tea _____ coffee.
- 7. The cat leapt _____ the wall and disappeared _____ the garden.
- 8. We must finish the project _____ Friday, so we cannot afford to wait _____ the last day.
- 9. He is not capable _____ telling a lie.
- 10. The two brothers divided the mangoes _____ themselves.
- 11. A thick fog hung _____ the valley _____ sunrise.
- 12. Ananya apologised _____ the teacher _____ being late.

Answers:

1. at, at; **2.** since; **3.** on; **4.** on; **5.** through (or by); **6.** to; **7.** over, into; **8.** by, until; **9.** of; **10.** between (two brothers); **11.** over, until; **12.** to, for.

Note on 10: "between" is correct because there are two brothers (for more than two, use "among").

Drill 2: Passage with blanks

Fill each blank with one suitable word, usually a preposition.

Meera woke up (1)___ dawn and looked (2)___ the window. A light mist was drifting (3)___ the fields. She dressed quickly and ran (4)___ the stairs. Her grandfather was already sitting (5)___ the veranda, sipping tea (6)___ a steel glass. "Come and sit (7)___ me," he said. They watched the sun rise (8)___ the hills, and she felt grateful (9)___ the quiet morning. Before long, the village began to stir (10)___ life.

Answers:

1. at; **2.** out of / through; **3.** over / across; **4.** down; **5.** on; **6.** from / in; **7.** beside / with; **8.** over / above / behind; **9.** for; **10.** into.

Conjunctions

A conjunction joins words, phrases or clauses. There are three families:

TYPE	JOB	WORDS	EXAMPLE
Coordinating	Join equal parts	and, but, or, nor, for, yet, so	He was tired, **but** he kept running.
Subordinating	Join a dependent clause to a main clause	because, although, if, unless, while, when, since, as, till, so that, whether	**Although** it rained, the match went on.
Correlative	Come in pairs	either...or, neither...nor, both...and, not only... but also, whether...or, hardly...when, no sooner...than	**Not only** is she kind, **but also** brave.

Choosing the right conjunction

RELATIONSHIP	USE	MINI-EXAMPLE
Addition	and, as well as, moreover	She sings and dances.
Contrast	but, yet, although, though, whereas, while, however	Though poor, he was generous.
Reason	because, since, as, for	We stayed in because it was raining.
Result	so, therefore, so... that	He ran so fast that he won.
Condition	if, unless, provided that, in case	Unless you hurry, you will miss the bus.
Time	when, while, as soon as, before, after, until, since	As soon as the bell rang, we left.
Purpose	so that, in order that, lest	He worked hard so that he could pass.
Choice	or, either...or, otherwise	Leave now, otherwise you will be late.



KEY POINT

Rules to remember: (1) *Neither* goes with *nor*, *either* with *or*. (2) *Hardly / scarcely* pairs with **when**/before; *no sooner* pairs with **than**. (3) After *unless* do not add "not": "Unless you work..." means "If you do not work...". (4) *Lest* is followed by *should*: "Run lest you should miss the train." (5) *Though* and *but* never sit together in one sentence.



BOARD ALERT

Board alert: "Although he was tired, but he kept working" is wrong. Use either "Although he was tired, he kept working" or "He was tired, but he kept working."

Drill 3: Fill in the conjunction

- 1. I wanted to buy the bag, _____ it was too costly.
- 2. _____ you leave now, you will miss the last bus.
- 3. He is not only intelligent _____ also hardworking.
- 4. Hardly had the lecture begun _____ the lights failed.
- 5. Take an umbrella _____ it should rain.
- 6. _____ she was ill, she attended the rehearsal.

- 7. Neither the Principal _____ the teachers were aware of the plan.
- 8. No sooner did he sit down _____ the phone rang.
- 9. Speak softly _____ the baby should wake up.
- 10. Do you know _____ the shop is open on Sundays?

Answers:

1. but / yet; **2.** Unless (or If you do not leave); **3.** but; **4.** when; **5.** in case (or lest, which then needs “should”); **6.** Although / Though; **7.** nor; **8.** than; **9.** lest; **10.** whether.

Drill 4: Join with the word in brackets

- 1. The roads were flooded. We reached school on time. (although)
- 2. Finish your homework. You cannot go out. (unless)
- 3. He ran fast. He caught the train. (so... that, rewrite as one sentence about running)
- 4. She saw the snake. She screamed. (as soon as)
- 5. He is poor. He is honest. (though)
- 6. I will wait. You come back. (until)

Model answers:

1. Although the roads were flooded, we reached school on time.; **2.** Unless you finish your homework, you cannot go out.; **3.** He ran so fast that he caught the train.; **4.** As soon as she saw the snake, she screamed.; **5.** Though he is poor, he is honest.; **6.** I will wait until you come back..

Verbs and Tenses

The tense of a verb shows **when** an action happens and **what kind** of action it is. Master the twelve forms below, then learn the signal words.

TENSE	SIMPLE	CONTINUOUS	PERFECT	PERFECT CONTINUOUS
Present	I write	I am writing	I have written	I have been writing
Past	I wrote	I was writing	I had written	I had been writing
Future	I shall write	I shall be writing	I shall have written	I shall have been writing

TENSE	USE	SIGNAL WORDS / CLUE
Simple present	Habits, general truths, fixed timetables	always, every day, usually, never; "The sun rises in the east."
Present continuous	Action happening now or planned near future	now, at the moment, look!, these days
Present perfect	Past action with a result now; unfinished time	already, yet, just, ever, never, since, for, so far, recently
Present perfect continuous	Action begun in the past and still going on	since, for, how long, all day
Simple past	Finished action at a stated past time	yesterday, last week, in 2010, ago
Past continuous	Action in progress at a past moment, or interrupted	while, when, at 5 p.m. yesterday
Past perfect	The earlier of two past actions	before, after, by the time, already
Future forms	Predictions, promises, plans	tomorrow, next week, soon; will/shall, going to



KEY POINT

Since vs for: *since* + a point in time (since 2019, since Monday); *for* + a length of time (for five years, for two hours). Both usually need a perfect tense: "I have lived here **since** 2015", "I have lived here **for** eight years."

Time clauses and the future

After *when, while, before, after, as soon as, until, if, unless* in a future sentence, use the **present** tense, not will: "I will call you when I **reach** home." (not "will reach").

Conditionals

TYPE	IF-CLAUSE	MAIN CLAUSE	EXAMPLE
Zero (truth)	simple present	simple present	If you heat ice, it melts.
First (likely)	simple present	will / can / may + verb	If it rains, we will stay in.
Second (unlikely, imagined)	simple past	would / could + verb	If I were a bird, I would fly to you.
Third (impossible, past)	past perfect	would have + past participle	If she had studied, she would have passed.



SIDEKICK TIP

In the second conditional, use **were** for all persons in formal English: "If I **were** you...". The same goes for *wish*: "I wish I **were** taller."

Subject-verb agreement

RULE	CORRECT EXAMPLE
A singular subject takes a singular verb	The list of names **is** on the board.
Words between subject and verb do not change it	The teacher, along with her students, **was** present.
Each, every, either, neither, one + singular verb	Each of the boys **has** a ticket. Neither of them **was** late.
Subjects joined by *and* take plural, unless they name one thing	Bread and butter **is** my breakfast. Tom and Jerry **are** friends.
With *either…or / neither…nor* the verb agrees with the nearer subject	Neither the captain nor the players **were** ready.
Plural-looking singular subjects: news, mathematics, physics, measles, ethics	The news **is** good. Mathematics **is** difficult.
Collective noun as a unit is singular; as individuals, plural	The jury **has** given its verdict. The jury **are** divided in their opinion.
Subjects like scissors, trousers, spectacles, police, cattle are plural	The police **have** arrived.
One of the + plural noun, singular verb	One of my friends **lives** abroad.
Amounts and distances treated as a single quantity are singular	Fifty kilometres **is** a long way.

Modals at a glance

MODAL	USE	EXAMPLE
can / could	ability; permission; possibility	She can swim. Could I borrow your pen?
may / might	permission; possibility	It may rain. You might need a coat.
must	strong obligation; deduction	You must wear a helmet.
should / ought to	advice, duty	You should see a doctor.
shall / will	future; offer (shall I); promise (will)	Shall I open the window?
would	polite request; habit in the past; second conditional	Would you help me?
need / dare	negative and question forms without to	He needn't come. How dare you!



BOARD ALERT

After a modal, use the base verb. "She can sing" (not "can sings", not "can to sing"). After *to* as a preposition (look forward *to*, used *to*), the next word is usually *-ing*: "I look forward to **meeting** you."

Verb forms: -ing, to-infinitive, or base

AFTER THESE	USE	EXAMPLE
enjoy, avoid, finish, mind, practise, suggest, deny, keep	-ing form (gerund)	She enjoys **dancing**.
want, hope, decide, promise, refuse, manage, afford, learn	to + base	He decided **to leave**.
let, make, see, hear (an action completely)	base form (no to)	Let him **go**.
stop	-ing = quit; to = pause in order to	He stopped **smoking**. He stopped **to rest**.
be, get used to	-ing	I am used to **waking** early.

Drill 5: Verbs and tenses

Fill each blank with the correct form of the verb in brackets.

- 1. She _____ (live) in Mysuru since she was born.
- 2. When I reached the station, the train _____ (already / leave).
- 3. If I _____ (be) you, I would apologise at once.
- 4. The children _____ (play) in the garden when it began to rain.
- 5. Neither the teacher nor the students _____ (know) the answer.
- 6. We will go to the beach as soon as the rain _____ (stop).
- 7. He suggested _____ (visit) the museum on Sunday.
- 8. The news of the victory _____ (be) announced yesterday.
- 9. By next June, I _____ (complete) my course.
- 10. She wishes she _____ (can) swim.
- 11. Each of the players _____ (get) a medal.
- 12. I _____ (wait) here for an hour and he has still not come.
- 13. My uncle, who _____ (live) in Canada, will visit us soon.
- 14. If she had left earlier, she _____ (catch) the flight.
- 15. The scissors _____ (be) on the shelf.

Answers:

1. has lived; **2.** had already left; **3.** were; **4.** were playing; **5.** know; **6.** stops; **7.** visiting; **8.** was; **9.** will have completed; **10.** could; **11.** gets; **12.** have been waiting; **13.** lives; **14.** would have caught; **15.** are.

Note on 5: the nearer subject is "students", plural, so the present tense **know** is correct. In 8, "news" is singular and the time word is "yesterday", so **was**.



HOT QUESTION

HOT: Which sentence is correct, and why? (a) "I have seen him yesterday." (b) "I saw him yesterday." (c) "I am seeing him yesterday."

Answer: (b). *Yesterday* names a definite finished time, so the simple past is needed. The present perfect cannot be used with a past time word.

Recap

- Learn dependent prepositions as pairs; read the whole sentence before choosing.
- Match conjunction to relationship: addition, contrast, reason, result, condition, time, purpose.
- Time words decide the tense. After time and if clauses, use the present for future meaning.
- Agreement follows the real subject, not the nearest noun.
- After modals use the base verb; learn which verbs take -ing and which take to.

06

CHAPTER · ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Functional Grammar II: Voice, Speech and Sentence Transformation

This part covers the rewriting skills that decide the second half of Question 5: active and passive voice, direct and indirect speech, transformation of sentences and error spotting. Each topic has rules, tables, drills and answers.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Active and passive
- Direct and indirect speech
- Transformation
- Synthesis
- Error spotting
- Mock Question 5

Active and Passive Voice

In the **active voice** the subject does the action. In the **passive voice** the subject receives the action. Use the passive when the doer is unknown, unimportant or better left unnamed.

Formula: object of the active sentence becomes the subject, the verb becomes **be (in the same tense) + past participle**, and the old subject follows **by** (if needed).

TENSE	ACTIVE	PASSIVE
Simple present	She writes a letter.	A letter is written by her.
Present continuous	She is writing a letter.	A letter is being written by her.
Present perfect	She has written a letter.	A letter has been written by her.
Simple past	She wrote a letter.	A letter was written by her.
Past continuous	She was writing a letter.	A letter was being written by her.
Past perfect	She had written a letter.	A letter had been written by her.
Simple future	She will write a letter.	A letter will be written by her.
Future perfect	She will have written a letter.	A letter will have been written by her.
Modal	She can write a letter.	A letter can be written by her.



KEY POINT

The perfect continuous tenses and the future continuous have no natural passive in ICSE practice. Questions will usually use the tenses above.

Special cases

TYPE	ACTIVE	PASSIVE
Question (do/does/did)	Who wrote this poem?	By whom was this poem written?
Yes/No question	Did he break the window?	Was the window broken by him?
Command	Close the door.	Let the door be closed. / You are ordered to close the door.
Request	Please open the window.	You are requested to open the window.
Two objects	The teacher gave me a book.	I was given a book by the teacher. / A book was given to me by the teacher.
Pronouns	She helped him.	He was helped by her.
Intransitive verbs	He slept.	No passive possible
Agent unimportant	Someone has stolen my bicycle.	My bicycle has been stolen.



SIDEKICK TIP

Pronoun change: I→me, we→us, he→him, she→her, they→them, and back: me→I, us→we, him→he, her→she, them→they.

Drill 6: Change the voice

- 1. The gardener waters the plants every morning.
- 2. The students were cleaning the hall.
- 3. Who has broken this vase?
- 4. A famous architect designed the building.
- 5. Please send the parcel today.
- 6. The committee will announce the results next week.
- 7. They are building a new bridge.
- 8. Did the manager sign the document?
- 9. Water is boiled by the cook. (to active)
- 10. The match was won by our school team. (to active)
- 11. The old man had told us a strange story.
- 12. One must obey the rules.

Answers:

1. The plants are watered by the gardener every morning.; **2.** The hall was being cleaned by the students.; **3.** By whom has this vase been broken?; **4.** The building was designed by a famous architect.; **5.** You are requested to send the parcel today. / Let the parcel be sent today.; **6.** The results will be announced by the committee next week.; **7.** A new bridge is being built by them.; **8.** Was the document signed by the manager?; **9.** The cook boils water.; **10.** Our school team won the match.; **11.** A strange story had been told to us by the old man. / We had been told a strange story by the old man.; **12.** The rules must be obeyed..

Direct and Indirect Speech

Direct speech quotes the speaker's exact words inside inverted commas. **Indirect (reported) speech** reports them in the reporter's own words, with changes to tense, pronouns and time words.

Step 1: Change the reporting verb and conjunction

TYPE OF SENTENCE	REPORTING VERB	CONJUNCTION
Statement	said, told (someone), explained	that
Question (wh-)	asked, enquired, wanted to know	the same wh-word
Question (yes/no)	asked, enquired	if / whether
Command / order	ordered, told, commanded	to + base verb
Request	requested, begged	to + base verb
Advice	advised, urged	to + base verb
Exclamation	exclaimed with joy / sorrow / surprise	that
Wish	wished, prayed	that / that... may

Step 2: Tense back-shift when the reporting verb is in the past

DIRECT	INDIRECT
Simple present (I write)	Simple past (he wrote)
Present continuous (I am writing)	Past continuous (he was writing)
Present perfect (I have written)	Past perfect (he had written)
Simple past (I wrote)	Past perfect (he had written)
Past continuous	Past perfect continuous
will / shall	would
can / may	could / might
must	had to (obligation); must (unchanged for deduction)

Step 3: Change pronouns and time/place words

DIRECT	INDIRECT
now	then
today	that day
tomorrow	the next day / the following day
yesterday	the previous day / the day before
last night	the previous night
next week	the following week
ago	before
this / these	that / those
here	there
come	go

Pronouns: first person matches the speaker (subject of the reporting verb), second person matches the listener (the object of the reporting verb), third person usually stays the same.



BOARD ALERT

No tense change when the statement is a universal truth or a habitual fact, or when the reporting verb is in the present or future tense. "The teacher said, 'The earth revolves round the sun.'" → The teacher said that the earth revolves round the sun.

Examples

TYPE	DIRECT	INDIRECT
Statement	Rohan said, "I am preparing for the exam."	Rohan said that he was preparing for the exam.
Wh-question	She asked me, "Where do you live?"	She asked me where I lived.
Yes/No question	He asked, "Have you finished the work?"	He asked if I had finished the work.
Command	The officer said to the soldiers, "March ahead."	The officer ordered the soldiers to march ahead.
Request	She said to him, "Please help me."	She requested him to help her.
Exclamation	He said, "Alas! I have lost my wallet."	He exclaimed with sorrow that he had lost his wallet.
Negative command	Mother said, "Do not play with fire."	Mother told us not to play with fire.

SIDEKICK TIP

In a question, the reported sentence goes back to **statement order**: “She asked where I **lived**”, not “where did I live”. No question mark in indirect speech.

Drill 7: Change the speech

- 1. Meena said, “I will visit my aunt tomorrow.”
- 2. The teacher asked, “Why are you late today?”
- 3. He said to me, “Don’t touch the wires.”
- 4. She said, “I have lost my keys.”
- 5. My friend said, “Can you lend me your notes?”
- 6. The captain said to the team, “Let us play fairly.”
- 7. The guide said, “Water boils at 100 degrees Celsius.”
- 8. Ravi said to Sita, “Were you at the party last night?”
- 9. “What a beautiful sunrise!” she said.
- 10. The doctor said to the patient, “You must take rest.”
- 11. (to direct) The stranger asked me whether I knew the way to the station.
- 12. (to direct) He told her that he would call her the next day.

Answers:

1. Meena said that she would visit her aunt the next day.; **2.** The teacher asked him/her why he/she was late that day.; **3.** He told me not to touch the wires.; **4.** She said that she had lost her keys.; **5.** My friend asked if/whether I could lend him/her my notes.; **6.** The captain proposed to the team that they should play fairly.; **7.** The guide said that water boils at 100 degrees Celsius.; **8.** Ravi asked Sita if she had been at the party the previous night.; **9.** She exclaimed with delight that it was a very beautiful sunrise.; **10.** The doctor advised the patient that he must take rest. (or: advised the patient to take rest); **11.** The stranger asked me, “Do you know the way to the station?”; **12.** He said to her, “I will call you tomorrow.”.

Sentence Transformation

Transformation means rewriting a sentence in a different form **without changing its meaning**. These are the patterns the paper loves.

1. Degrees of comparison

POSITIVE	COMPARATIVE	SUPERLATIVE
No other city in India is as large as Mumbai.	Mumbai is larger than any other city in India.	Mumbai is the largest city in India.
Few boys are as tall as Raj.	Raj is taller than most boys.	Raj is one of the tallest boys.

2. Too... to / so... that / enough

PATTERN	EXAMPLE	TRANSFORMATION
too... to	He is too weak to walk.	He is so weak that he cannot walk.
so... that	She was so tired that she could not stay awake.	She was too tired to stay awake.
enough	He is strong enough to lift it.	He is so strong that he can lift it.
not... enough	The tea is not hot enough to drink.	The tea is too cold to drink.

3. Affirmative, negative, interrogative, exclamatory

FORM	EXAMPLE
Affirmative	She is the best singer in the school.
Negative	No other singer in the school is as good as she.
Interrogative	Is there any singer in the school better than her?
Exclamatory	What a wonderful singer she is!
Assertive (to exclamatory)	It is a very hot day. → How hot the day is!

4. Simple, compound, complex

TYPE	RULE	EXAMPLE
Simple	One clause	Seeing the lion, the children ran away.
Compound	Two main clauses joined by and, but, so, or	The children saw the lion and ran away.
Complex	Main clause + subordinate clause	When the children saw the lion, they ran away.

5. Using participles, infinitives and other devices

ORIGINAL	TRANSFORMED
He finished his work. Then he went for a walk.	Having finished his work, he went for a walk.
She wanted to buy a gift. She went to the market.	She went to the market to buy a gift.
He was ill, so he could not attend.	Being ill, he could not attend. / Because he was ill, he could not attend.
He is rich, but he is unhappy.	In spite of being rich, he is unhappy.
As soon as he arrived, the show began.	No sooner had he arrived than the show began. / Hardly had he arrived when the show began.
Work hard or you will fail.	Unless you work hard, you will fail.
It is raining heavily. We cannot go out.	Because it is raining heavily, we cannot go out.



KEY POINT

Inversion after negatives: with *no sooner, hardly, scarcely, never, rarely, seldom, not only* at the start, the helping verb comes before the subject: "Never have I seen such a crowd." "Not only did she win, but she also broke the record."

6. Other useful patterns

- **Unless / if not:** "If you do not hurry, you will be late." = "Unless you hurry, you will be late."
- **Despite / in spite of + noun or -ing:** "Although it was cold, we went out." = "In spite of the cold, we went out."
- **As... as:** "Meera is not as tall as Rani." = "Rani is taller than Meera."
- **Because / owing to:** "He missed the bus because of the rain." = "He missed the bus because it rained."
- **Passive and active swaps** often appear inside transformation items. Check both.

Drill 8: Transform as directed

- 1. Gold is more precious than iron. (Begin: Iron...)
- 2. He is so careless that he cannot be trusted. (Use too)
- 3. The boy was too shy to speak. (Use so... that)
- 4. Although she tried hard, she failed. (Begin: In spite of)
- 5. As soon as the bell rang, the students rushed out. (Begin: No sooner)
- 6. If you do not study, you will not pass. (Use unless)
- 7. Very few cities are as large as Delhi. (Use the comparative)
- 8. What a delightful surprise! (Make it assertive)
- 9. She is the cleverest girl in the class. (Use a negative)
- 10. The old man was weak and could not climb the stairs. (Use too)
- 11. It is a very hot day. (Make it exclamatory)
- 12. He studied hard. He wanted to win the scholarship. (Use to-infinitive, one sentence)

Answers:

1. Iron is less precious than gold.; **2.** He is too careless to be trusted.; **3.** The boy was so shy that he could not speak.; **4.** In spite of trying hard, she failed.; **5.** No sooner had the bell rung than the students rushed out.; **6.** Unless you study, you will not pass.; **7.** Delhi is larger than most cities.; **8.** It is a delightful surprise.; **9.** No other girl in the class is as clever as she.; **10.** The old man was too weak to climb the stairs.; **11.** How hot the day is!; **12.** He studied hard to win the scholarship..

Synthesis: Joining Sentences

Join the sentences without using *and* every time. Choose the pattern that matches the relationship.

PATTERN	EXAMPLE
Participle phrase	Opening the box, she found a letter.
Relative clause	The man is my uncle. He lives next door. → The man who lives next door is my uncle.
Noun in apposition	Mr Rao is our Principal. He is a poet. → Mr Rao, our Principal, is a poet.
Infinitive	He went to the bank. He wanted to deposit money. → He went to the bank to deposit money.
Gerund after a preposition	He was punished. He had lied. → He was punished for lying.
Subordinating conjunction	She was tired. She finished the work. → Though she was tired, she finished the work.

Error Spotting and Correction

Many ICSE items give a sentence with one error, or a passage where each line has to be edited. Check these seven suspects in order:

1. Subject-verb agreement
Does the verb match its real subject?

2. Tense
Does it fit the time word and the surrounding sentences?

3. Articles
a / an / the used correctly? (an hour, a university, the Himalayas, no article before most abstract nouns used generally)

4. Prepositions
Is the preposition tied to the verb or adjective?

5. Pronouns
Does the pronoun agree with its noun, and is it in the right case (I vs me)?

6. Comparatives
Double comparison (more better) or wrong form of than/from?

7. Word order and idiom
Misplaced adverbs, double negatives, wrong word (much/many, fewer/less)

ERROR	WRONG	CORRECT
Agreement	The quality of the mangoes are poor.	The quality of the mangoes is poor.
Tense	He is working here since 2018.	He has been working here since 2018.
Article	She is an university student.	She is a university student.
Preposition	He is good in maths.	He is good at maths.
Pronoun	Between you and I, it is a secret.	Between you and me, it is a secret.
Comparative	He is more smarter than me.	He is smarter than I (am).
Double negative	I don't know nothing.	I don't know anything. / I know nothing.
Fewer / less	There are less students today.	There are fewer students today.
Each other / one another	The two friends hugged one another.	The two friends hugged each other.
Adjective vs adverb	She sings beautiful.	She sings beautifully.
Misused word	He gave me an advice.	He gave me some advice. (advice is uncountable)
Superlative	He is the most tallest.	He is the tallest.
Reflexive	He hurt him.	He hurt himself.

BOARD ALERT

Board alert: when asked to correct a passage, change **only** the word that is wrong. Rewriting the whole line can cost marks, even if your version is acceptable.

Drill 9: Find and fix the error

- 1. The furniture in the room were very old.
- 2. She has been absent since three days.
- 3. Neither of the answers are correct.
- 4. He prefers tea than coffee.
- 5. I will meet you when I will reach Delhi.
- 6. Each of the girls have brought her book.
- 7. We discussed about the budget.
- 8. The number of applicants are increasing.
- 9. He is one of the boys who has won a prize.
- 10. If I was rich, I would buy a car.

Answers:

1. were → was (furniture is uncountable and singular); **2.** since → for; **3.** are → is; **4.** than → to; **5.** will reach → reach; **6.** have → has; **7.** delete "about" (discussed the budget); **8.** are → is (the number... is); **9.** has → have (the relative pronoun "who" refers to "boys"); **10.** was → were.

Mock Question 5 (15 marks)

Attempt all in 25 minutes. Do not look at the key until you are done.

A. Fill in the blanks with a suitable word (preposition or conjunction) *(5)*

Last summer my family went (1)____ a trip to Ladakh. We flew (2)____ Delhi to Leh and landed there (3)____ noon. The altitude made us dizzy, (4)____ the guide advised us to rest (5)____ a full day.

B. Fill in the blanks with the correct form of the verb in brackets *(5)*

By the time we (6) (arrive), the shop (7) (close). If I (8) (know) that earlier, I (9) (leave) sooner. The children (10) (play) in the park every evening.

C. Rewrite as directed *(5)*

- 11. "Where are you going?" the old woman asked me. (Indirect speech)
- 12. The workers are repairing the road. (Passive voice)
- 13. He is so ill that he cannot walk. (Use too... to)
- 14. Although she was nervous, she sang well. (Use in spite of)
- 15. Having finished the work, he went home. (Use as soon as)

Answer Key

1. on; **2.** from; **3.** at; **4.** so; **5.** for; **6.** arrived; **7.** had closed; **8.** had known; **9.** would have left; **10.** play.

C: 11. The old woman asked me where I was going. **12.** The road is being repaired by the workers. **13.** He is too ill to walk. **14.** In spite of being nervous, she sang well. **15.** As soon as he had finished the work, he went home.

HOT QUESTION

HOT: Explain, with an example, why "I have been to Mumbai last year" is wrong, and correct it in two ways.

Answer: The time phrase "last year" fixes a finished past moment, which needs the simple past. Corrections: (1) "I went to Mumbai last year." (2) "I have been to Mumbai" (drop the time word, or add "twice", "once").

Recap

- Passive = be (same tense) + past participle; the object becomes the subject.
- Reported speech: change the reporting verb, conjunction, tense, pronouns and time words.
- Transformation keeps the meaning: too/so, comparison, voice, complex/simple, negatives with inversion.
- Error spotting: check agreement, tense, article, preposition, pronoun, comparative and idiom.
- Attempt every item; Question 5 has no choice.

07

BONUS CHAPTER · ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Listening and Speaking: Internal Assessment

Twenty marks come from Listening (10) and Speaking (10), assessed during the year. Here is exactly how it works and how to score.



IN THIS CHAPTER

- Listening test
- Speaking test
- How the 20 marks are split
- Score-boosting tips

NEW Listening Skills (10 marks)

The examiner reads a passage of about **300 words** aloud **twice**: first at normal speed (about 110 words a minute), then more slowly. You may make brief notes while listening. You then answer an **objective-type test** on the passage.

- Class X has **two assessments** during the year.
- In the first reading, listen for the main idea. In the second, catch names, numbers, places and reasons.
- Write only keywords in your notes. Do not try to write sentences.

NEW Speaking Skills (10 marks)

You make an **oral presentation of about two minutes**, followed by a **discussion of about three minutes** with the examiners. You usually get about an hour to prepare and a choice of subjects.

POSSIBLE TYPE OF SUBJECT	WHAT TO DO
Narrating an experience	Beginning, middle, end. Use the past tense and a feeling
Providing a description	Move from general to detail. Use the five senses
Giving directions to make or operate something	Use sequence words: first, next, then, finally
Expressing an opinion	State your view, give two reasons, one example, then conclude
Giving a report	Who, what, where, when, why
Relating an anecdote or commenting on a current event	Keep it short, personal and clear



BOARD ALERT

You may glance at brief notes, but **reading out or depending too much on notes will be penalised**. Keep to short keywords.

NEW How the 20 Marks Are Awarded

SKILL	MARKS
Listening Skills	10
Speaking Skills	10
Total sent to CISCE	20



SIDEKICK TIP

Speak at a calm, steady pace, look at the examiner, and finish with a clear closing line. A confident two minutes beats a rushed three.

Done reading? Now go break the board.



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